Reply from Shingo Kawamura

Shingo Kawamura
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In both my band rehearsals and programming classes, I have observed that learning rarely follows a straight line. A passage is played, mistakes surface, adjustments are made, and we try again. A program is written, bugs emerge, revisions follow, and the cycle repeats. These loops are central to how learning unfolds in my classrooms. Action research, therefore, resonates with me because it frames these iterative processes not as incidental but as intentional opportunities for inquiry and growth.

After reflecting on how these cycles show up in my own teaching, I searched Google Scholar for a resource that might help me connect this practice with action research more directly. That led me to Mertler's (2021) article, which narrows the focus from broad research design (as in Creswell, 2018, and Suter, 2012) to the specific ways teachers can use action research to address problems of practice. This zoomed-in perspective gave me a practical lens for considering how action research might shape my own classrooms.

What especially stood out to me was his discussion of rigor. He emphasizes that credibility increases as teachers repeat cycles of inquiry, triangulate data, and engage participants through strategies such as member checking (inviting participants to review data or interpretations to confirm accuracy) and debriefing. This framing reminded me of *kaizen*—the Japanese principle of continuous improvement through small, repeated adjustments. The parallel is clear: in both band and coding, cycles of rehearsal or iteration are already present, and action research provides a structure for transforming those cycles into systematic inquiry.

Mertler (2021) gives the example of teachers providing online lessons during the COVID-19 pandemic. Many adapted quickly, experimenting, testing, and refining their approaches without realizing they were already engaging in teacher inquiry. I connected with this example because, at the time, I also didn't know about teacher inquiry as a method—I was simply trying my best to deliver education under challenging circumstances. Looking back, I can see how those trial-and-error adjustments were a form of inquiry. What action research adds, as Mertler suggests, is a framework for making those instinctive cycles more intentional, systematic, and reflective.

This cyclical perspective also aligns with the First Peoples Principles of Learning (FPPL), which emphasize that learning is holistic, reflexive, experiential, and relational. While teaching in Lax Kw'alaams, a First Nations community in northern British Columbia, I often reflected on the salmon runs that sustain both people and land. Salmon depend on unbroken cycles and healthy rivers; their journey is linear (upstream and downstream) and rhythmic, requiring persistence through repeated stages of return. Similarly, action research unfolds in cycles—plan, act, observe, reflect—that mirror the salmon's passage. In my band rehearsals, these cycles appear naturally—play, listen, adjust, repeat—just as they do in programming projects, where design, testing, and refinement follow a similar pattern. Both processes highlight the importance of iteration and renewal.

Mertler (2021) also highlights that mentors and collegial support are vital for teachers new to action research. Here the salmon metaphor extends further. Even healthy rivers contain debris, and obstacles such as dams can block the salmon's progress. In teacher inquiry, those obstacles may take the form of limited time, uncertainty, or lack of confidence. Mentors and colleagues play a critical role in "clearing the debris," offering guidance and encouragement so that teachers can persist in the cycle. In this way, collegiality does more than provide support—it sustains the rigor of the action research process itself.

At Richmond Christian, we have recently developed new ADST and Fine Arts learning standards that emphasize cycles of creation, reflection, and refinement. Action research provides a framework for strengthening these standards in practice and for connecting them more closely with the Core Competencies. Following our recent government evaluation as an independent school, I see action research as a bridge between provincial priorities (e.g., FPPL and Core Competencies) and the daily rhythms of teaching and learning.

Although elements of action research are already present in my practice, I recognize that I have often engaged in them intuitively or by accident. What excites me is the opportunity to develop these practices with greater intentionality—designing inquiries, gathering data, and listening carefully to student voices. In doing so, my natural inclination to tinker and refine can evolve into structured cycles of inquiry that strengthen both my teaching and my students' capacity to become co-investigators in their own learning.

References

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